



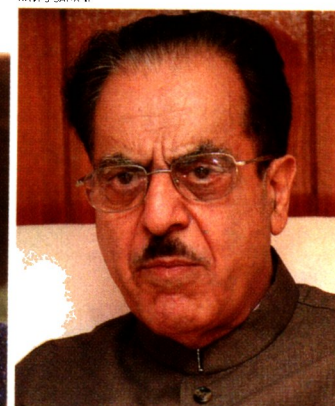
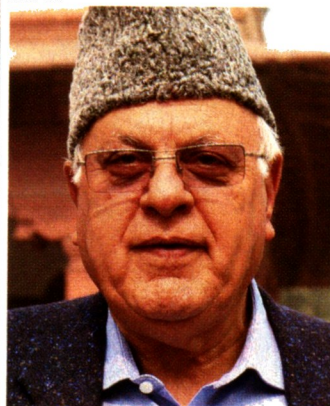
promptly extended its Jammu bandh to August 14—part of its calibrated strategy to mount pressure on the UPA Government and to keep up the tempo of protests. “The agitation will continue till the Government addresses the core issue,” said Sharma, reiterating the samiti’s “no-land-no-deal” stance. “It involves our religious faith and there can be no middle ground,” he added.

In hindsight, it was a mix of the Kashmir-fixated expediency, political chicanery and administrative miscalculation and mishandling that has pushed the state to the brink. Even after the genie of the land transfer to the board was let out by previous governor Lt-General A.K. Sinha, evoking a flare-up in the Valley, N.N. Vohra, his predecessor and an experienced hand on Kashmir, botched up the crisis in its early phase by implementing the Centre’s brief on dousing the Kashmir rage, in a tearing hurry. Vohra’s step, without keeping the Jammu politicians in the loop, backfired, sparking unrest in Jammu on June 30.

POLITICS LESS NATIONAL: Mehbooba Mufti (left), Abdullah (below left) and Soz

SUPRA DAS

RAVI S. SAHANI



“Kashmiris perceive that the land transfer will undermine their special status under Article 370.”

MEHBOOBA MUFTI, PDP CHIEF

Gandhi sought its help to defuse the crisis—has made little headway. Patil could bring the samiti on board only after he agreed to its representatives’ precondition on a meeting without NC’s Farooq Abdullah, state Congress chief Saifuddin Soz and PDP’s Mehbooba Mufti—all three part of the all-party delegation and accused of being “villains of the piece” for opposing the land transfer to the shrine board. Stung by Patil’s non-committal stance on the land transfer issue, the samiti

Today, even after the highway supply line has been restored, the turmoil has forced the violence-wary transporters in Jammu as well as Kashmir to keep off the road, fuelling the separatists’ high-pitched propaganda on “a continuing economic blockade” of Kashmir which has spread like a wildfire across the Valley, evoking spontaneous response to offload the fruit crop in POK. By all reckoning, the Jammu agitation has now snowballed into a manifestation of the region’s long-nursed sense of discrimination stemming from Kashmir’s dominance in matters of power-sharing, delimitation of Assembly seats and development. “Jammu has always received the short end of the stick in the past 60 years, and the Amarnath land issue has given a vent to its pent-up regional aspirations,” said Brigadier (retd) Suchet Singh, a leading member of the samiti.

The impact of a debilitating economic loss—estimated to be over Rs 2,000 crore—is being felt